

NOVELISTIC SCREENPLAY

POKÉMON NOCTURNE

EPISODE 14

The Limits of Justice

Author

Adelbert Vervloet

Working compilation

Status · draft · pass 1/3 recorded · EN-GB apparatus

Format	Novelistic screenplay · EN anchors
Target duration	To be set — corpus ≈ 90 min read aloud
Scenes	23
Version	2026-09-24 · EN-GB dossier after P1

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Episode sheet

Series Pokémon Nocturne

Episode 14 — The Limits of Justice

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Logline

Houndoom is not Gold/Richter's. The white spectre has a name. Red comes home by telephone. Apollo declines redemption. Justice does not save every soul.

Place in the arc

Due: Houndoom in the lists; Venusaur / Blue; Mean Look.

Paid: the mentor; Misty; Apollo in the flesh; “Farewell, Pokédex holders.”

Open: the Coyote still; Gold/Richter at Cerulean; Red among the living.

Characters — this episode only

Name	Function here
Gold/Richter · Red	Combat; collapse; Route 25
Karin	Mentor; Houndoom lent. she/her.
Misty	Cerulean; the voice; tea
Apollo	White spectre; Houndoom; the limits of justice
Houndoom / Haunter / Charizard	Lent, not a trophy; Curse; Charmander named

Places (EN anchors)

Mt. Silver · Indigo Plateau (the glasshouse) · Cerulean Gym / house · Route 25.

Technical notes — outside the scenes

Heading	Note
Curse (move)	Battle modification: Curse is not cancelled on recall.
Houndoom	Borrowed from Karin. “It isn’t mine either.” Not a trophy.
OST titles	Could Not Be Caged, Don’t Listen to Her, Light in This Darkness, Lamento, Si Dolce: pieces. Distinct narrative titles.
Stat drops	Stat drops are not cancelled by recall. They typically last through each battle. In alignment with physical integrity.
Banal evil	Arendt / series gel. Not “mundane evil”. Vampire Messiah kept. But no prolongation of Arendt’s theory
Dynamic between Apollo and Gold/Richter	Richter Belmont and Olrox in Castlevania Nocturne

Screen durations (excluding titles)

It isn't mine either ≈ 1 min 07 + 40–50 s. Mentor 1 min 07. Spectre 2 min 30–3. Frustration ≈ 3 min 20. Syndrome ≈ 2 min 40. Materialised spectre ≈ 3 min 15–45. Lessons ≈ 1 min 20–25.

BGM index — pieces (Nocturne OST)

Scene	Piece	Range
Houndoom / Snorlax	Your Choice	00:00–01:07 · 03:34–end
The mentor	Part of the Same Story	00:00–01:07
Misty / telephone	Powerful Predatory Deadly	00:46–01:24
Misty / telephone	My Sister	00:00–00:30
The spectre in white	Making Monsters	00:00 · 00:14–end
Haunter	Could Not Be Caged	entry · 00:47–01:20
Don't Listen	Don't Listen to Her	entry
Light	Light in This Darkness	entry
Lamento della Ninfa	Lamento della Ninfa (Trailer Version)	entry
Imperfect Choices	A World to Win	entry
The call / collapse	Powerful Predatory Deadly	02:21–end
Apollo	Greatwords	00:00–00:35
Apollo	You've Seen the Devil	entry
Route 25	Si Dolce È 'l Tormento	entry · alternative opening
Farewell	Please Don't Leave Me	–0:08 · 00:20–01:12

BGM index — traces

Address only.

Scene	BGM
The Successor's Frustration	EP01 S02 15:12–15:54
The Successor's Frustration	EP07 S01 11:24–12:46
The Successor's Frustration	EP03 S02 08:50–10:17
Mountain Syndrome	EP08 S02 23:42–24:40

Order of scenes

1. It Isn't Mine Either
2. A Sober Mentor
3. Distant Imminence
4. The Spectre in White
5. The Successor's Frustration
6. Could Not Be Caged
7. The Implacability of Nature
8. The Flame Tempered by Water
9. Unknown Kin

10. The Hallucinogenic Bait
11. Dependence on Strangers
12. Don't Listen to Her
13. The Redemption of Sin
14. Light in This Darkness
15. Exceptions and Ordinary People
16. We Must Awaken
17. Lamento della Ninfa
18. Imperfect Choices
19. An Urgent Call
20. Mountain Syndrome
21. The Materialised Spectre
22. Si Dolce È 'l Tormento
23. Some Lessons Are Too Heavy to Learn Alone

The scenes are inserted here. The close follows the body.

Scene — It's not mine either

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 4–5 hours*

BGM 'Your Choice' 00:00 → 00:18

A stream of water flowed towards the spring, very close by. The moon broke through the clouds and cast a polar glow over the patchy snow. Nothing had yet come back to life. The air, however, had.

Gold/Richter remained calm. A sense of shame, however, a compromise. Houndoom stood as usual. Healthy hostility. Deference towards that which deserved to be confronted. Ready.

Red and Espeon, no. They were already subservient — to the legend, to the bark that had never been, to what Red's body knew before his species did. Espeon too still in its fur. Red, his jaw too sharp. Houndoom merely pricked up one ear. That was enough.

BGM 'Your Choice' 00:18 → 00:38

Pursuit. Sucker Punch. The back off-limits. A shift in weight, barely a micro-gesture, and the projected terror resumed.

Gold/Richter signalled several calm gestures. Red read them. They were still in battle. He pulled himself together.

Espeon seized the initiative. Quick Attack, without a target, a momentary burst of speed, double the caution. It did not turn its back.

Houndoom tracked it down on instinct, almost organically. The synchronisation was more unsettling than the contact itself.

BGM 'Your Choice' 00:38 → 00:52

Espeon grew more cautious. It looked as though it wanted hand-to-hand combat. Ambiguous. A diversion. Never its back.

Houndoom hounded the spot relentlessly. A threat. Not taken to the limit. The obvious disadvantage was enough. They resigned themselves to it.

BGM 'Your Choice' 00:52 → 01:07

The exchanges intensified. Then Houndoom lunged, fiercer, faster. No move. No bite. A lower-pitched howl — not the infernal one, but enough to land a blow.

Red resigned himself to the stalemate. A more spirited stance than usual. Espeon countered with Quick Attack, dodging, without turning its back. As soon as it reached a safer distance, almost in mid-air, Red recalled it. Bold. As long as the Ball was in flight, nothing was lost. When it touched his palm, the danger subsided. A sense of relief.

BGM 'Your Choice' → 01:07

Red watched. Houndoom had not really pursued him all the way.

BGM 'Your Choice' 03:34 → 03:56

He threw it. Snorlax emerged. Its massive form took up the snow-covered ground.

Gold/Richter recalled Houndoom at once. The Poké Ball nestled between three fingers, just right.

Red understood. Not to crush it. To make Espeon withdraw. Nothing more. Without cruel excess. Recruited, not out of malice.

A sigh. Red's curiosity remained:

'What a surprise... that you've got this Pokémon...'

Residual concern. No accusation.

Gold/Richter read the intention. He waited a few seconds:

BGM 'Your Choice' 03:56 → end

"This Pokémon isn't mine either."

Red blinked. Gold/Richter hinted:

"...It belongs to someone... exceptionally wise and generous..."

End of scene

Scene — A sober mentor

The League — *by a fountain, summer evening, high altitude*

BGM 'Part of the Same Story' 00:00–01:07

The moon shone through the windows. No one else was there. A fountain, some bushes, the damp scent of plants. The air was cool.

Karin was looking after Umbreon, Murkrow and Houndoom. They had almost shed the stereotypes associated with their types: more docile, almost good-natured. She stroked them without any apparent wariness, with a confidence that was far from naivety. The underlying dynamics remained complex.

Gold/Richter stood apart, firm, unhurried. The visit was inconvenient, unannounced. He was in no position to complain. He simply observed, patient and calm.

BGM 'Part of the Same Story' 00:18 → 00:38

Karin finished. She turned round.

'You were keen to become my student. Although I don't really anticipate what you need from me...'

Gold/Richter tried to dispel the flattery.

"This is the most daunting challenge of my life... Your expertise will no doubt determine the outcome. I would be honoured by your kind assistance, should you deign to grant it to me..."

She read the dilemma in his awkwardness.

He continued, in a lower voice:

"I've managed to keep certain problems at bay, thanks to others. Not entirely, though. Sometimes they get the better of me. Given your specialism, I don't know who else to turn to in order to rise above this..."

BGM 'Part of the Same Story' 00:38 → 00:52

Karin rose without haste. The Pokémon moved aside slightly. Murkrow found a more suitable perch.

"Ever since we first met, your unique qualities have been striking. They coincide with some of my own... My premonition told me you would come. But you had your own path to discover. You've succeeded..."

BGM 'Part of the Same Story' 00:52 → 01:07

She adjusted her position, facing him squarely.

In the night-time light, the Darkness exuded a strange, distinct gentleness. No malice. A warm welcome. Karin simply said:

"I was fortunate enough to be your mentor..."

Gold/Richter made no attempt to probe further. A restrained sense of contentment. All he had to do was wait. The answers were imminent.

End of scene

Scene — The Distant Imminence

Two locations — an autumn day

At the Cerulean Gym, the light was flat, almost clinical. Misty was already holding the receiver. She hadn't hung up since the beginning.

On the hillside, in the village of Mt. Silver, Gold/Richter stood out of Red's sight. The air was thinner. He spoke more quietly than he ought to have.

'I am prepared to challenge Red.'

The statement was matter-of-fact. Too much so, for him. It passed Misty's ear without her really hearing it. A fleeting unease: the wait of many long years had just been given a date, and dates are frightening.

"...I don't intend to lose," he said. "But I can't guarantee anything."

Misty closed her eyes for a moment. When she spoke again, her tone combined a glimmer of hope with a touch of pragmatism — not that she thought he was weak. She refused to underestimate Red:

'...Very well.'

Gold/Richter felt he owed her another favour. He leaned slightly towards the void, a vague bow that he would not have made to any other Gym Leader.

"I'm sorry if I wasn't strong enough to undeceive him."

“Why do you say that, you who defeated me?”

He fell silent. His impertinence came back to him too late. Standing before her — before her physical maturity, before what she had become — he had spoken like an envoy of Red’s, not as an equal.

“...Even so, you deserve to know this. You can prepare yourself. When he returns, perhaps...”

He almost heard himself giving in. He hadn’t meant to.

“I saw him.”

BGM ‘Powerful Predatory Deadly’ 00:46–01:24

At Misty’s place, something rusty jolted. She held back. Too many illusions had already taken their toll.

She asked, as if it were no big deal:

“What does he look like now?”

Gold/Richter searched for the words without embellishing them.

‘...You’ve changed too much. He’s almost the same, physically. I can’t say for certain. He’d like to marvel at your prosperity... if that were possible.’

He did not sugar-coat it. She took the awkwardness in her stride and did not press him further. A hand, on the Cerulean side, had come to rest on the wooden counter. Gold/Richter asked:

“Do you want to see his photo...?”

Misty thought for a moment:

“...I’d rather hear his voice, actually.”

Gold/Richter barely relaxed his shoulders.

“Well, you can expect to hear it again.”

The mood was a little offbeat. She revelled in it briefly — then her hope turned cautious once more.

BGM: ‘My Sister’ 00:00 – 00:30

“I’ve got nothing but good luck to wish you... Even from someone who isn’t in a position to bring that idiot back. It’s probably pointless.”

The self-deprecating tone held firm. Gold/Richter shook his head, up there, pointlessly.

“Do not underestimate yourself. I was afraid to challenge him. He is still... much the same as before, in some positive ways.

His exemplary upbringing is largely down to you. Even if that’s not enough to bring him round.

You cannot resolve everything on your own. Let the others help with him too.”

He was surprised to hear himself say it. It was an inaccurate description. A brief, joyful silence fell on both ends of the line.

Then he continued, in a lower voice, and the delight faded.

BGM ‘Making Monsters’ 00:00–00:44

“Nevertheless... your information would be invaluable.

Is there anything stopping Red from staying here...?”

Misty knew the story. She hesitated. Her gaze drifted towards the water in the gym, without really seeing it.

BGM “Making Monsters” 00:14–00:44

‘He had recurring nightmares... A spectre... dressed in white...’

Gold/Richter’s eyes widened. The mountain air seemed even thinner. Speculation. Nothing concrete. The clues remained incomplete.

End of scene

Scene — The spectre in white

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 4–5 hours*

BGM ‘Making Monsters’

The patchy snow still bore Snorlax’s footprints. A suspended silence.

Gold/Richter spoke first.

‘Anyway... why are you reacting like this to that borrowed Pokémon... It makes sense given its fame. Not so much for you, though...’

Red tried to suppress a painful memory. The jawline was all too clear.

“I decided to leave... after hearing it bark for the first time.”

BGM ‘Making Monsters’ 00:14 → 00:44

Something sinister, something wrong, passed through Gold/Richter.

Red continued, in a lower voice:

“Then a black darkness behind the crows...”

Gold/Richter gave a scathing look. The realisation had already dawned on him. Red elaborated:

“Without us realising it, these ominous Pokémon have invaded the region... As if summoned by the ghost to punish me. I’d crossed the line...”

“...The Old Man Coyote...?”

The horror deepened. But the worst was yet to come.

“...I’m not sure,” replied Red. “An urban legend back home. The reason why the Professor didn’t congratulate me on my League victory...”

Gold/Richter had suspected as much. He, too, was not unscathed.

Red waited a moment:

BGM 'Making Monsters' 00:14 to the end

"But the most horrifying thing... is the spectre in white..."

Gold/Richter had the feeling he'd met someone horrible before.

A fleeting, laconic glimpse. White hair, too stark against the night sky. An almost entirely white suit. A black tie. Light, cold eyes, devoid of passion. A graceful posture, slightly in three-quarter profile, as if pausing at the threshold of a case file. No hatred. No contempt. No snobbery.

Red continued:

'...A spectre... dressed almost entirely in white. Graceful. Cold. Without hatred, contempt or snobbery. Simply administrative. Bureaucratic. Procedural. Like a civil servant consulting files. When he smiled, it was merely the confidence of doing his job. Nothing more. And perceptive. As if I could hide nothing.'

Another flash: the same face, a shadow of wire mesh across the cheek — Silph, perhaps. The smile a little more pronounced. Still professional.

"Back in the day, at Silph Co.," said Red. "We don't know if he was human. He visited me in my dreams. Time and again. That's my ultimate reason for leaving..."

"Has that nightmare stopped...?"

"...No. Far less often. How should one describe it...? The regulator of banal evil? Vampire Messiah...?"

The jest fell flat. It offered no relief. Red recalled with bitterness:

"Since then, I've realised... he was the opposite of Giovanni. Giovanni crushes us head-on. He remains in the shadows. Goes unnoticed. He doesn't even need to be there. All he has to do is open the cages. Set his minions free... vampires, monsters, creatures of the night... He just needs to increase their numbers. Even a supreme power isn't capable of eradicating them all."

Red pauses for a moment:

"So I had to accept that my gamble was unrealistic. Reckless. Greedy. I can't make up for all that..."

Even further down:

"A man's voice on the radio, during the occupation of the tower... reminded me of those spectres. That voice was unfamiliar to me."

Only a slight sense of relief: the pain finally had an outlet, however incomplete.

End of scene

Scene — The Successor's Frustration

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 4–5 hours*

The snow had not budged. Snorlax was still there.

Gold/Richter said only:

‘Apollo.’

Red seemed to snap out of a daydream. Gold/Richter emphasised:

BGM ‘EP01 S02 15:12–15:54’

“He’s a living white spectre. His name is Apollo.

But it is strange... He told me you had never seen him in person. Was that a lie...?”

Several seconds passed. Red did not break down. Just a single, bitter blow, taken in his stride.

“So... what I saw wasn’t him. The old man borrowed his identity to warn me...”

Gold/Richter nodded ever so slightly.

“But I did. In the radio tower.”

A sense of melancholy quickly came over Red. He’d already worked it out.

“...So it was you who foiled their plan back then...”

“Not just me.”

“All the better. Sorry you couldn’t escape the same fate.”

Gold/Richter hastened his pace. He gave no sign of being shaken.

Red asked, almost in spite of himself:

“What was he like, this Apollo...?”

“...Unusually intelligent. Even our precociousness isn’t enough to consistently outdo him.”

“So why can he be so formidable...?”

“I won’t say too much for now. In short: the old man chose him because he excelled at repurposing what already existed. Not at reinventing everything. At optimising the Old Man Coyote’s corrupt system.”

He whistled. The sound of flapping wings came from the darkness. Two Golbat. Gold/Richter called one back. The other landed on his arm — a predatory instinct, almost a pretence. Red followed the creature’s movements more than his words. Gold/Richter explained:

‘...They’re not just for spying. They’re also here to prove it to you. To save on words.

To investigate you, they’re spared synthetic moves. Feigning organic savagery. I trusted their instinct. Ritualised predation. Primitive.

That is Apollo’s method. It isn’t confined to Pokémon. It’s in all humans. Not just since yesterday. From much further back. All he needs to do is direct it. To manipulate it surreptitiously. That’s why you can’t manage to root it all out.”

Red found it hard to believe—the tactics used against him, the way Gold/Richter had pulled it off. The Golbat blinked. Gold/Richter recalled it quietly and put the Poké Ball away.

BGM “EP07 S01 11:24–12:46”

"...I also found it hard to accept that all this came from someone anonymous... or from a shadowy regime. We know almost nothing about them."

Red, further down:

"...So that was the ultimate ugliness you saw?"

"...No."

Red's surprise was palpable. Gold/Richter elaborated:

'I'm not dismissing his crimes. But he and his kind aren't the most hideous. Nor are those at the very bottom. Nor the most destitute.

Those who have minimal access: security, stability, education, intellect. And who act out of desire, out of ego, not out of need. They exploit what remains more greedily, without considering the consequences. Narratives. Moral capital. Self-aggrandisement.

The most insidious evil recycles this chimera. We can no longer identify the true enemies."

Red felt uneasy. A nameless sense of remorse:

"Luckily you defeated them... Team Rocket."

"No. I have suppressed them. Not quite defeated them."

He picked up on the first name as one picks up a thread.

"Red. I had given up some of my raw power so as not to repeat Green's mistake. I don't know the reason: integrity, moral superiority... I cannot bring myself to compound the grief of someone who has already lost so much by surpassing him. Others might be able to. Not me.

My strength was not enough against Apollo. I needed the others."

Red looked away for a moment. Gold/Richter was saddened. Red said:

"I was hesitant to go there... At least, I owe him a debt of gratitude for sparing me that."

"...The Old Man Coyote's real target was you. Giovanni was just bait."

BGM 'EP03 S02 08:50–10:17'

The horror returned, lingering, older than the snow.

Gold/Richter continued, his voice tighter:

"I had the means to resist. Certain weaknesses were exploited against my will. My courage was sapped. Without you — without those who carried on your momentum, Misty, Lance — I wouldn't have regained my bravery."

He drew the hunting crop partway from its scabbard. He took Houndoom's Ball from his pocket. He did not release it.

'To survive, I've sometimes had to resort to this brutality to defeat Apollo's Pokémon.

Apollo said that Pokédex holders were potentially the most dangerous monsters of all. It was provocative. It concerned you. And me. He was right.

I set out to find a way out for you. My journey crossed paths with Team Rocket. I saw just how much we were alike. One wrong decision is all it takes to slip.

Houndoom embodies what I fear most. Just how much of a monster I could become. Just how impure I am by nature.”

A sardonic smile, directed at himself.

“...Ironically, in Kanto, I had to draw on some of Apollo’s theories to see through the rhetoric. Sometimes we survive by drawing on the wisdom of our worst enemies.

I thought I didn’t want to surpass you. I eventually realised... You’re more independent than I am.”

Red shook his head ever so slightly:

“...I’m not sure I’d be able to cope in your shoes...”

Gold/Richter’s smile shifted. Ambiguous conviction. Determination still clumsy, incomplete — enough for Red to see the intention: the challenge was not a crowning achievement.

“It’s not putting myself down. It’s objectivity. I’m more vulnerable than you. By far. And I’ve had to endure all this humiliation.”

End of scene

Scene — Could Not Be Caged

Mt. Silver — high slopes, 4–5 hours

Gold/Richter rummaged through a Ball and threw it. Haunter emerged.

BGM: ‘Could Not Be Caged’

Red and Snorlax stood at the ready. Destiny Bond. The subterfuge. A latent scepticism: Gold/Richter was holding an evolvable Pokémon. No one made a show of the stratagem. It could only be heard.

Towards the river, something was collapsing. Snow was falling into the water.

Haunter took an erratic course. It was impossible to tell whether it was moving away or drawing nearer. It was drawing nearer. It was almost suicidal, given its vulnerability.

Red and Snorlax waited. No clear attack. Little physical threat. Red shifted position, making himself a little more visible to Snorlax.

The moment came. A gesture from Red. Snorlax braced itself.

A more intricate, complex gesture from Gold/Richter. Haunter spread its hands — an esoteric enticement. Hypnosis. Its eyes emitted mysterious, drowsy waves.

Snorlax’s attempt was thwarted.

BGM ‘Could Not Be Caged’ 00:26 → 00:47

Haunter shifted slightly. A slightly unnatural angle — like a brief, restrained assault. Its composure faltered for a few seconds. Curse.

Gold/Richter ensured it. He recalled his Pokémon. Immediately: Skarmory.

BGM “Could Not Be Caged” 00:47 → 01:20

A faint flicker of surprise flickered across Red’s face.

Metal Sound, without delay. Snorlax anticipated it and deployed **Block**.

A dead end. A sense of claustrophobia amidst the vast expanse of snow. Skarmory’s panic spread to Gold/Richter. A hasty move, already a compromise.

Aerial Ace. Almost unscathed—and yet disoriented by Block, with no way back, like an irreversible path. The damage was considerable. Snorlax’s HP held out.

Crunch. Hit. Skarmory’s defence dropped, ever so slightly.

Second Aerial Ace: don’t waste it.

Body Slam. Skarmory faltered. The move’s delay, despite Block, gave it a chance to escape.

A more sweeping gesture from Red. Blizzard.

Skarmory and Gold/Richter were surprised that this move existed here. No dodge. Skarmory on the brink.

Second Blizzard. Roost, spontaneous. Flying-type suspended. Drastic recovery beneath the icy blast.

The Blizzard ceased. Something was amiss: Skarmory was not moving. Frozen. It had been planned for a long time.

Snorlax did not hesitate. Another Blizzard. The panic became visceral.

BGM ‘Could Not Be Caged’ 01:34 → 01:54

Then the anomaly: Snorlax suffered damage far greater than Skarmory could have inflicted.

A flash of lightning. Haunter’s devious manoeuvres. Red pieced it together. Curse.

Disarray. Snorlax: the affliction, a futile sacrifice if recalled — Curse would not be cancelled. Skarmory: frozen, escape on hold, still able to take the hit.

Panic on both sides. Gold/Richter at an impasse, in the snow. Red pondered.

He no longer pressed to spur Snorlax on for a transactional reason.

BGM ‘Could Not Be Caged’ 01:54 → end

He recalled it. The Poké Ball in his palm.

Gold/Richter was taken aback — Skarmory’s continued ambiguity was throwing him off balance.

Red called out, smoothly. Charizard.

Flamethrower, without waiting for the command. Skarmory was freed from the ice and struck at its weak point. Exhausted. The damage was offset by the freezing. The settled snow obscured the trail: liquefaction, a temporarily damp trail.

Gold/Richter beheld the flame. Empathy for the pain — and a long-awaited delight.

Red examined the Ball. Snorlax was exhausted by Curse.

Gold/Richter was not naive. Merely opportunistic.

‘Why this decision?’

A few seconds.

“It’s ethically burdensome. That’s all.”

Red’s satisfaction was not apparent.

End of scene

Scene — The Implacability of Nature

The League — *gathered around a fountain, a summer’s evening, high up*

The moon was still rising. It was clear they had already spoken to one another. Umbreon had moved closer to the fountain. Murkrow, higher up. Houndoom, on the ground, its flank in the warm twilight — the same body as on the mountain, another legend.

There was a sullen look in Karin’s eyes. Her eyes were not wet. Yet it was enough for Gold/Richter to misinterpret them.

‘Very well. That is all that troubles you. This Apollo.’

“...Are you crying... over someone like him...?”

She did not raise her voice.

“Tears can be deceiving. We shed them, we give ourselves a reason. Rejecting them entirely prevents us from growing.

No. I feel no sadness for him. For you. And for the burden you have taken on.

He was undeniably ingenious. He excelled at exploiting instinct. By distorting it. Not using it properly. What a waste.”

Gold/Richter slumped a little, helpless, gloomy. Houndoom turned its ear, not towards the name — towards him.

BGM “EP06S02 00:30–01:50”

“...I have managed to neutralise Team Rocket,” he said. “Including him. By using their own methods...

The Johto connection has enabled me to contain the cost of this savagery. Occasionally, I don’t have full control over all the repercussions. If it were to take hold of me at a critical moment...

That is why I cannot turn to anyone of your calibre. Your approach aligns with his, yet diverges on minor points. Almost the same Pokémon. The result, however, is quite different. You are his antithesis.”

A restrained smile. Contentment without triumph. Umbreon rubbed itself against the edge of the basin, as if the remark had given it leave.

“However... is it true?” he asked. “The intrinsic savagery...?”

"I'm afraid so."

Cold. Businesslike. Not detached.

"But it really is unmanageable..." he said. "Inevitable...?"

Karin did not reply straight away. Murkrow changed perches.

Gold/Richter lowered his gaze:

"I see... you didn't get too involved in Ecruteak simply out of detachment. My apologies..."

BGM 'Part of the Same Story' 01:10—end

"I was trying to avoid being misunderstood. To prevent the Dark-type Pokémon from posing as public heroes. To stop people from taking them at face value."

"I wouldn't have escaped that preconception if you'd acted differently. Ever since Apollo, I've recognised your foresight..."

"It doesn't bother me. I was right on that point. Certain parallels were visible early on. They became deeper later. My decision allowed us to prolong them."

A comfort. He did not justify himself. He no longer felt too much guilt. Houndoom rested its head.

Karin continued, in a lower voice.

"I chose the Dark-type Pokémon too to evoke the terror of nature, the darkness that lies dormant within us all. And a certain illusion of civilisation.

Whether it's a form of wisdom, or an instinct — that intrinsic savagery."

Gold/Richter's eyes widened:

"Is that raw wisdom...?"

"It depends. But yes. We presume to judge. We stigmatise species that are not very 'intelligent'. Their moves are not very refined."

'...Indeed. No TMs. Barely powerful enough.'

"It goes beyond that. Our Pokémon pull off the big moves because they have our support, our remedies. Apparently, a civilisation. Also a dependency. In the wild, a luxury.

Out there, they adapt to climate, danger, competition, with an inherent wisdom, however raw. In civilisation, that same wisdom can be more devastating—desire, ego—and more predictable. We call ourselves more civilised. A mirage.

Certain species are born hunters. Houndoom. Arbok. Murkrow. Golbat. I cannot ignore that fact, merely to contradict Apollo."

Houndoom did not stir. That was no denial.

Gold/Richter pondered:

'I've been wondering: if they understand us, why do they obey? To become stronger? To benefit us? Is the bond real? This cruelty, irredeemable...?'

"They may follow us for that reason. Their cruelty may not stem from them. From nature.

We glorify nature to make humans seem tiny. Yet nature can be relentless. To survive it, a Pokémon adapts, changes, becomes cruel — not always of its own free will.

They trust us. Security, stability. That distances them from that cruelty. Their goodness can unfold. I refine my own by channelling their instincts in a more just direction. I am not a fatalist. Your approach already foreshadowed that we would come together.”

He had not anticipated this familiarity. Yet it came all the same.

‘But must we defy nature...?’ he asked, in a burst of curiosity.

“We must treat it with respect. But it can be alien, arrogant. By humanising it enough, without conquering it, it provides shelter and maintains harmony. It all comes down to human potential.”

A memory flashed through his mind, though he didn’t put a name to it: the Old Man Coyote relies on that potential whilst distorting it; Mewtwo doesn’t believe in it.

Karin concluded, without any solemnity.

“This echoes our tradition. Ho-oh. Lugia. Perhaps the Creator. They recognise good and evil. They cultivate good. They know just how precious it is, and resilient, with clear-sightedness. You’ll pull through.”

Gold/Richter felt a great weight lift from his shoulders. One regret remained:

“I was such a fool not to see it. To have been so afraid...”

“Fear is certainly not a harmful symptom. It may indicate that one’s conscience remains unclear. That there is still work to be done. To be developed. It allows us to move forward.”

He felt relieved. Not a panacea. For a moment, he marvelled at his own foolishness. Murkrow drew its wing back. The moon remained unchanged.

End of scene

Scene — The flame tempered by Water

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 4–5 am*

Gold/Richter remained stunned. Not by defeat. By a clumsy sense of wonder.

Red took note. He recalled Charizard. To dispel the spell.

The Poké Ball retracted. Gold/Richter returned.

‘Why the daydreaming...?’ asked Red.

“This feeling is paradoxical... A faint pang of sorrow for my companion. And a reverential fear of this flame... Is it... protective...?”

Red turned the Poké Ball in his palm for a moment.

“I may be misinterpreting it. But if it reflects your hesitation, your lack of conviction... I am not responsible for your fate. I cannot leave you to bear this burden.”

"It was no surrender. Nor a free pass. You deserve the truth. I had to pour my heart out to someone worthy."

Red was taken aback. He considered it: Gold/Richter had cast off a long-standing burden — and yet he still held on. Gold/Richter exclaimed:

"...I've wanted to see the flame of your Charizard with my own eyes. For a long time."

Red looked at the Poké Ball. A sombre sense of nostalgia. Contrition.

BGM "EP04 S01 22:05–22:41"

"...Yes. It's almost my emblem. People admire it for its appearance. Attractive. Gallant. Chivalrous. On a more superficial level.

But the price is steep. I dragged him into this with Green. I let him face his childhood friend. He's angry with me. As if I'd been wrong to choose him..."

"Do not deny your nature.

Green rejected his own. You, on the other hand, respected it."

That cut short the gloom. Cleanly.

Gold/Richter continued, more calmly.

"I know nothing of Kanto. In Johto, people remember your courage more than your glories. A bit of a sycophant. Enough for common sentiment.

Since Team Rocket, I've become even more certain of this. Apollo favoured cheaper Pokémon with effective biological moves. He probably wouldn't have considered Charizard. Too rare.

BGM 'EP04 S01 22:40–24:12'

Charizard is not merely the antithesis of Blastoise; he is also the antithesis of Houndoom, and of Apollo himself.

Houndoom is not the mightiest of the mischievous. Apollo used it to embody his essence. To perpetuate the corrupt order.

Charizard isn't the strongest either. Just as you weren't. But you didn't let the darkness devour the world."

Red listened too intently to look away, yet was too overwhelmed to reply. Gold/Richter continued:

'Among the Kanto starter Pokémon, its natural moves are quite powerful, even without TMs. It's as if it were born to fight evil. An imperfect paladin. Destined to counter malice. Perhaps that's your nature. It has allowed me to respect you as you deserve.'

The compliment was sincere, if a little awkward. No sycophancy.

"What encouraged me to challenge you wasn't just the data," explained Gold/Richter. "Your resolve. Your integrity. And after I saw the flame..."

A flash. The scope. A Flamethrower, Golbat or Misdreavus. The sense of wonder already there, hazy, austere.

"You're not the same anymore. Some qualities... are still there," Gold/Richter added. "That flame didn't burn everything to ashes. It's sophisticated. Dampened by Water. Thanks to Misty's feelings..."

A nameless languor washed over Red. He longed to quench his thirst. The barriers held firm. Gold/Richter nodded in agreement:

"So trust in your nature. In your connection to it. Even if that connection isn't enough to get you out of here..."

End of scene

Scene — The Unknown Kin

Mt Silver — *high slopes, 4–5 hours*

Red looked away for a moment, as if to shake off the overwhelming feeling.

BGM "EP03 S02 08:10–08:50"

"Out of curiosity, why are you so persistent...?"

Gold/Richter did not reply straight away. His gloves clenched shut, then opened again:

"It's not just my own initiative. I'm also acting on the orders of Ho-Oh and Lugia."

Red looked up. His surprise was evident. Then something older surfaced — a realisation beginning to take shape.

"...So Ho-Oh was here... for you...?" said Red.

"Did Master Ho-Oh reveal himself to you...?"

In Gold/Richter, a flurry of emotions: turmoil, a nameless jealousy, a flutter he hadn't asked for. He clenched his jaw. Held it in. It wasn't favouritism. Red had needed it.

Red searched the snow, his gaze fixed on the ground:

"...Months ago. In the snow. When I nearly gave up the will to live. To free myself once and for all..."

His voice slowed. He was going over it all in his mind.

"It emerged at dawn, above dark clouds. Its path wasn't heading towards me. Merely calculated to be seen. Irrefutable beauty. Not divine grace. More commonplace. A melancholy, almost human. A mercy that came from ordinary people... As if they understood without setting me free. To remind me that someone still loved me down below. And that it had come on their behalf.

I thought it was just my loved ones in Kanto... But it wasn't just them."

Red turned his face towards Johto. In the moonlight, the region remained vague, blurred. A panorama one has gazed upon for too long.

"He came from Johto too. From you, no doubt.

I must have looked at that every day. Visible. Untouchable. Barely describable. I never explored it. So close to my heart, perhaps."

End of scene

Scene — The Hallucinogenic Bait

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 4–5 hours*

Gold/Richter took out a Poké Ball and tossed it into the river, smoothly, in a spot that seemed just about right. Lanturn emerged. A low commotion. The surface settled. He moored the boat.

BGM “EP05 S02 15:40–16:35”

Red read the invitation. Not Lapras, which had already been taken out. Not Charizard, which was at a disadvantage here. Espeon — whilst Houndoom remained behind. Gold/Richter gave nothing away. Under pressure, still feeling the lingering fear, Red sent out Espeon.

They prepared themselves.

Espeon unleashed Psychic. Instantaneous. Painful. Excellence in C, a slight deviation. Lanturn’s HP held out.

Lanturn, slower, fired off Screech. Red and Espeon paused for a moment: what was the point, if it wasn’t a powerhouse? The situation took a turn for the worse. They didn’t have time to stick to their plan.

A second Psychic, a little more focused. A visible amplification — though not necessarily real.

Second Screech. The screech was loud, acoustically abominable. A repulsion. No tangible damage.

Lanturn wouldn’t last a third one. Gold/Richter assessed the situation.

At the intersection—Screech, Psychic arming himself—he called out. Stupor. The missed prey.

The Poké Ball in his palm. Haunter.

A slight sense of relief: it wasn’t Houndoom. Vigilance waned. A sense of urgency.

Red’s movements fell into sync. Espeon charged up Psychic.

The approach was agile, unexpected, almost unavoidable. A hand struck out. Sucker Punch.

The impact, the noise. His guard already down. Alakazam’s damage still lingering. Espeon was sent flying to one side. He didn’t get back up.

Red stood there, dazed for a moment. The lapse. The carelessness under pressure. He admitted it. He recalled it.

“So you didn’t let it evolve to make the most of its strengths... the separated hands...”

“That’s similar to your approach... not letting Pikachu evolve. In a way.”

“But yours is more... calculated...”

A hint of sarcasm. Gold/Richter explained:

“Oh... Because I was saved that way... by a Kanto-style strategy...”

End of scene

Scene — The Dependency of Strangers

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 4–5 hours*

Red remained bewildered by the remark. Kanto. Saved in that way.

Gold/Richter turned his face slightly, directing his gaze towards the doorway over there.

BGM ‘EP05 S02 24:07–25:37’

“You should know... I’m from New Bark Town.

It was a rare opportunity to visit yours, whilst you look at mine almost every day. Not a metropolis. On the border. A gateway to Johto.

I had to find my way with the outsiders. Compared to the figures of Kanto, we aren’t quite as modern, nor as powerful as your figures. In your eyes, self-underestimation. Tradition can be reduced to a last resort to keep from collapsing.”

He continued, in a lower voice.

‘...And you, you’ve better embodied the values we claim as our own. You’ve made me re-evaluate outsiders. To believe that we could do something right. Like you.’

Red objected:

“But I’m not that perfect.”

“So we don’t idealise you. We respect you. Without idolising you.”

Red accepted this. A sense of gravity. No idol to shatter: just a correction. Gold/Richter explained:

‘I don’t speak for others. At my age, I was almost priestly. That underestimation, that xenophobia, could have pushed me towards tradition — blind, even morbid.

You’re not perfect. But the fact alone looms large. It transforms other lives.”

Gold/Richter’s gaze turned to Haunter:

‘It was a dirty trick. But that profile saved me in the end, against Team Rocket. His name is Eusine.’

A sense of gravity settled in, without any melodrama. Gold/Richter continued:

"We see him as eccentric, poetic. Passionate about our stories. Not a frenzy. A lucid enthusiasm. I cannot stop talking about it.

Irony: a sumptuous culture, and yet we're reassessing our fortunes through a stranger to regain our confidence.

BGM: 'EP06 S01 09:00–09:58'

You saved the world in the imperfect tense. He was no warrior. He did not abandon the children to fight alone. The same method as Apollo — Sucker Punch, a biological move — to save us. Gallant.

A seasoned trainer sheltered by a dilettante. A stranger. From Celadon. Surrounded by Murkrow and Houndoom."

The irony was clear. So was the gratitude.

"But the credit doesn't really go to Kanto," Red pointed out.

"Certainly not. Someone from that background can aspire to the light and live with dignity. It's... incredible."

Red refocused his attention. The remark had stirred something within him. Gold/Richter added:

"We thought we could set ourselves apart from Kanto, spiritually. In reality, we depend on it — at least on certain very promising individuals. You. Him. Otherwise, fossilised. Corrupted. A necessary concession.

...I haven't ended up like you. Not yet. Heredity. Eusine. You. You didn't have that chance... national disparity, clan-based — who knows."

Red anticipated what came next. It came. Gold/Richter concluded:

"Thanks to you, we've reassessed ourselves. Since you left. Even if imperfectly. We regret that we cannot help you, bring you relief... simply because we aren't really your people. Johto hasn't truly recovered from it. Worn down by this powerlessness..."

Their gazes held. In Red's eyes, the helplessness — visible, untouchable, like the panorama.

End of scene

Scene — Don't Listen to Her

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 4–5 hours*

BGM 'Don't Listen to Her' 03:16 → 03:30

Gold/Richter re-engaged in battle. An invitation, nothing more.

Red pondered. Who to save for last. Charizard under Curse: the thought came too quickly, visceral. He gambled on Lapras — Psychic early enough, despite Icy Wind.

The Ball. Lapras on the snow-covered ground. The centre wasn't secured. A breath too white at its nostrils.

They began again. A brief moment of complicity. Their fingers spoke.

BGM 'Don't Listen to Her' 03:30 → 03:55

Lapras charged up Psychic. Already too slow. Haunter shifted sideways, almost pointedly. Red watched *that* more than the wave.

The blow landed. Haunter slumped to the ground. Too late. Curse was sealed. Something irrevocable settled in the air, ritualistic, silent.

Gold/Richter called back. Not to buy time: to prevent Curse from piling up on an empty field. Lanturn on the ground. Two bodies already destroyed. The anxiety doubled.

Lapras concentrated. His eyes glowed.

Discharge struck first — Icy Wind had been enough to create that opening.

BGM 'Don't Listen to Her' 03:55 → 04:10

The two attacks clashed.

Lapras froze slightly. Paralysis. Its tiny movements grew sluggish. Metal Sound, still active, made Discharge's attack too powerful. Lanturn, for its part, buckled under Espeon's assault. Not another Psychic move.

Despite the paralysis, Lapras fired its beams again.

Lanturn read the situation. Discharge came too late. Without a command — extraordinary agility, almost indecent. Sucker Punch.

Lapras, Red, Gold/Richter: the same terror.

Lapras withstood the onslaught. Not enough to take it down. Psychic hung in the air for a second. It struck again. Lanturn took the decisive blow and collapsed.

BGM 'Don't Listen to Her' 04:10 → 04:21

Gold/Richter recalled it immediately. Again. No dirtier.

Red sensed Perish Song as an outcome already too close for comfort. To accept it. Not to accept it. Lapras held firm, concealed, a tactical pretence — a form still too full.

Gold/Richter produced the Ultimate Ball. His fingers betrayed his fear: the song, the final one, Charizard's imminent demise.

He was about to throw it.

BGM 'Don't Listen to Her' 04:21 → end

Lapras was drained by Curse. The pretence crumbled. The full form unravelled. It collapsed into the snow.

Gold/Richter felt spared. It didn't sink in.

Red closed his eyes. The chance to win with less effort had just slipped away.

And the other, heavier sign arose: not to go all the way if it was so grubby. An immeasurable burden lifted, joylessly.

End of scene

Scene — The Redemption of Sin

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 5–6 o'clock*

The mixed snow had taken on a bluer hue. The hour had passed without the wind changing. The final Ball remained in Gold/Richter's hand, unthrown. Lapras was now nothing more than a warm absence in the earth.

Gold/Richter shook off the weight with a question.

'So you're not fighting anymore... because I can't bear the weight...?'

Red did not reply straight away. A crystal melted at the edge of a stone.

"I don't know. At least, none of this is going to plan."

"Have you rediscovered the joy of battle...?"

"Not that I'm aware of. It's heavy. Not quite like when I faced Green..."

A smile, delightful, ambiguous. Relative relief: it wasn't the dreadful one. Nor was it childhood. Gold/Richter agreed:

"...All the better. I didn't come here to remind you of that joy."

"...No. We're no longer ordinary children. We can't do that without consequences..."

A shared silence. The river, further downstream, offered no comment.

Red fell silent. Regret came without any drama.

"I'm sorry..."

I saw the scars coming. The wounds. I don't know if I caused any more. I know my limits. I can't fix everything. So many scars — the world, other people, you. I wish I could have put things right. Even just a little. I can't take it any more...

You were spared this fate because of your origins. I wasn't. I can't truly ease your pain... simply because I'm not your kind...'

Gold/Richter nodded ever so slightly.

BGM: 'Family in Heart' 00:11–

"...I agreed with that. Completely."

A vague, indistinct flicker in Red's expression:

"Even Mewtwo would not have made it without that visceral bond. What use could I possibly be...?"

Gold/Richter's gaze drifted sideways, towards a barely discernible Johto.

"But you managed to go as far as saving the son of your worst enemy. So I was wrong."

Red struggled to take it in. The name did not exist yet.

“Giovanni has a son...?”

A smile played on Gold/Richter’s lips.

“The trials of the years, ever since you defeated Giovanni. He turned over a new leaf after his visit to us. Before it was too late. You didn’t spare him from adversity. From sin, yes.”

Something bitter gripped Red—not the son, but the fact that the world had carried on without him in that way.

“It works the same way for me,” Gold/Richter observed. “If you hadn’t saved the world, I’d have been even more miserable...”

Red almost protested.

‘...I’m not sure my influence is that far-reaching...’

“Neither do I. But if Giovanni — or even Green, at worst — had taken over Kanto, or even Johto... I wouldn’t have survived. I’m more vulnerable than you. I’ve had to resort to rather unsavoury methods. Without you, my hands would have been even more stained...”

He looked at his palms. As if the smell were still there.

The end of the BGM

Doubt lingered in Red’s eyes.

Gold/Richter looked at him. The melancholy faded, almost without pretence.

“So I cannot deny that I am in your debt,” said Gold/Richter. “Your path is hard. Imperfect. Not without its price.”

Red remained sceptical. The snow all around had settled nothing.

“Well then, I can at least preserve your dignity as a trainer...”

End of scene

Scene — Light in This Darkness

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 5–6 hours*

BGM ‘Light in This Darkness’

The quality of the shadows had changed. No longer quite night. Not yet dawn. A twilight hour. The patchy snow cast a faded blue; further down, the river was little more than a trickle. The two trainers hesitated. Weariness had settled in their wrists, in their jaws, in the thin air.

BGM ‘Light in This Darkness’ 00:11

Gold/Richter raised the Ball. A silent call.

Red read the situation. He played his last card.

They launched their attacks almost simultaneously.

Houndoom left fresh footprints — too clear, once again. Charizard took to the air. Its wing met the cold. This was not familiar territory.

Suddenly, the moment felt more solemn. The fingers spoke. The two bodies took their positions.

BGM 'Light in This Darkness' 00:24 → 00:52

Charizard lunged.

Flamethrower. A brief streak across the blue. Charizard dodged despite the proximity, feigning the ferocity of close combat — snout, heat, too close.

Houndoom stepped back. Hope faded. Charizard used the gap to his advantage and rose, higher than the comfortable range.

Background music: 'Light in This Darkness' 00:52 → 01:25

Silence. The moon was now but a faint remnant. The sky, as dawn approached, held a few scattered stars, as if forgotten. A glimmer was appearing in the east, very narrow, still without warmth. The snow barely reflected it.

Houndoom gazed up at the sky. Charizard was not quite within reach: the distance, the darkness. He watched steadfastly. Without giving up.

For Gold/Richter, the precariousness was more evident than for the beast. Victory weighed too heavily. Red held the initiative. But not the ease.

BGM 'Light in This Darkness' 01:25 → 01:52

Step by step, Charizard became visible. A mass darker than the sky. From a still manageable distance, Dragon Pulse. A ring, a wave. Houndoom circled round, effortlessly.

Charizard turned. He had crossed the clearing. He lowered his altitude to take aim.

The second Pulse charged up — and Charizard read the ambush. Dense. Dashing. Houndoom was no longer waiting: he *was on the lookout*.

Charizard rose again. A little more confidently. The distance, now unpredictable, disappointed Houndoom. Sucker Punch had, plausibly, just missed its window.

Charizard paused. Rose again. Assessed the situation.

Calm returned, more profound than the silence before. Neither was entirely disappointed. Vigilance remained. They watched one another — trainers, beasts — with patience already worn thin. The stubborn dawn barely advanced. The next move was already there, not yet made.

End of scene

Scene — Exceptions and Ordinaries

The League — *a garden by a fountain, a summer's evening, high altitude*

The moon streamed through the windows in narrow slivers. The water in the basin lapped steadily. No one else was there. Umbreon had pressed itself against the damp rim. Murkrow, higher up. Houndoom, in the warm half-light of the basins.

Gold/Richter was already revising. His fingers, too still.

‘You’ve opted for the Dark-type... out of sentiment, or inclination...?’

Karin hesitated. A sheet of paper stirred without a breath of wind.

“Not out of preference. As a warning.”

Her surprise was brief, almost internal. She placed her hand on Umbreon’s head. The creature allowed it — complacency, not submission.

“Umbreon evolves through intimacy. Why does a Dark-type creature need trust to make this progress...? Some creatures aren’t as wicked as they appear. Or perhaps it isn’t their nature. But twisted. Exploited.”

Gold/Richter found himself looking at Houndoom.

“But not all of that sort are worth saving...”

“Indeed. Some are incorrigible by nature. For others, it is too late — or not yet. We must cultivate our wisdom, intelligence and clarity of mind. We must discern whilst a life can still be saved.”

The encounter between Silver and Professor Elm. A memory without an image.

“Why does your kindness shine so constantly...?” asked Gold/Richter.

She raised her hand. Murkrow flew up and alighted on it, with precision. For a moment, Karin’s face looked angelic — but only for an instant. It touched Gold/Richter’s heart.

BGM ‘Source of Your Fury’

“I am proud of our heritage. Of our respect for the dignity of every life.

I’m less conventional. Less rigid than some of the more traditional folk. That’s allowed me to explore. Without the people of the past, I’d never have got this far.”

A sombre nostalgia came over him — his own fulfilment, too dearly bought.

‘Talents that are still latent are vulnerable to prejudice,’ she said. ‘Just as we stereotype the “Darkness” type. A hasty judgement can be fatal. A tolerant tradition is fertile ground.

My approach may seem ambiguous. Neutral in itself. Enticing. Without any anchors or corrections, I might have slipped. The exceptions are sheltered by kind, clear-sighted people.”

He lowered his voice slightly:

‘Yes... I do sometimes resort to rather unsavoury means...’

“You distinguish yourself not by force, but by the fact that you discern this so early on — even at great cost.

Lance, his privilege meant he was oblivious to certain details. He learnt with the prize. Even a slightly heightened clarity of mind can lead to great progress. Without it, I would not have passed it on. I am indebted to him.”

Murkrow shifted his weight, ever so slightly. Gold/Richter wondered:

‘...I don’t know why your teachings have been entrusted to me...’

“The elite, like us, are certainly not philosophers. Self-satisfied. Not the supreme ones. We translate values into power, to protect.

It is worth my while to share this with anyone who is willing to pay the price. Even if they grasp only a part of it.

And I sometimes have things to learn from you. As I do from Morty. So that the deaths of those dear to us are not in vain: so as not to reduce them to mere symbols. To learn from them.”

A smile from Karin. Humility, not posturing:

“Organic savagery... I don’t believe God has placed it within us merely to distinguish between good and evil. But so that we might put it to a more sensible use. From time to time.”

A warmth came over her. It did not dispel all the volatility:

“That healthy use... would probably become your greatest asset for this mission.”

The fountain had not stopped. Houndoom had not moved. The admonition lingered in the greenhouse like a light that did not blind.

End of scene

Scene — We Must Awaken

Mt Silver — *high slopes, 5–6 am*

Snow was falling lightly. Charizard held the air. Houndoom, the earth. A glimmer of dawn, still faint. Weariness had not left the two Trainers.

Red gazed out.

BGM ‘The Earth Needs the Dawn’

“You say you’ve been called to me... by your gods. But why...?”

“Because this world needs you...”

“I cannot eliminate all evil. Giovanni was driven back by me. Apollo, by you. The world is meant to be made better.”

“...No.”

Red’s eyes seemed hollow.

Gold/Richter continued, his tone heavier.

“Giovanni has vanished. His system can carry on... like a zombie. The casino. Pollution. Invasive species. The abandoned. Those who exploit your name to mete out justice. It’s hard to recognise this world anymore. Why this sacrifice? At times, I wonder if it would be cruel to bring you back...”

“Then we can manage without me.”

“But yes.”

Red was intrigued. His attention returned. Gold/Richter elaborated:

“We need you. Not because you’re the strongest. Nor because you’re the champion.

You don’t have to save the world. We must free Kanto from this imprecation — a childish dream. It’s painful. We can’t sleep, remain children, live as if it were a game, or relentlessly strive to be the strongest. We must wake up. Grow up.

The world must face reality. There’s no need to glorify heroes. But we must ensure they deserve their happiness, even after evil. So that others may embrace justice.

Restoring dignity to a life—with all its burdens, joys and attachments—is no easier than bringing back the dead.

We can weather the winter. We cannot erase it. It returns. Like the shadow after the light.

So we learn its nature. We grow stronger. We treat those we love as flesh-and-blood beings. And we pass it on.”

A flash of inspiration. Pryce. The Kimono Girls. Humble, austere, warm figures. Gold/Richter had spoken from the heart without realising it.

He looked up. Sincere tenderness.

“So the only way out is for you to come back.”

BGM ‘The Earth Needs the Dawn’ 02:11

Red pondered deeply.

BGM “The Earth Needs the Dawn” 02:16 → end of BGM

Charizard descended from the sky, in stages.

They all sensed it. The air shifted a notch.

Then came the sudden acceleration towards Houndoom.

Flamethrower—to limit its path, not for the damage.

Charizard used the restriction. An unpredictable advance. Houndoom was taken by surprise.

Dragon Pulse.

Houndoom dodged — and Charizard was already charging up Focus Blast, from a better range.

The terror of vulnerability. The anxiety was palpable in Houndoom; more subdued in Gold/Richter.

Houndoom faltered. Charizard switched to Wing Attack. Moderate damage. Slightly critical, given that defence.

The drift came at a cost. Faced with doubled resistance, Charizard held back, moved away slightly, and waited for the right moment.

Dawn, still uncertain, had not yet decided the outcome.

End of scene

Scene — Lamento della Ninfa

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 5–6 am*

A relative calm. Gold/Richter was still speaking, his attention wavering. Houndoom's breath was too pale. Charizard held his breath.

'...Red. I felt inferior to you. Quite simply... That spell tore away the one you loved. I cannot tarnish that by pretending to be better than you.

I misjudged: even such a clear-sighted love was not enough against the ultimate evil — so perhaps we could do without love. I was wrong about that.

I haven't escaped some of your mistakes. I couldn't avoid hurting the one I care about most. Not without consequence. That's what helped me understand your situation."

Red, a light-hearted joke, without sarcasm.

BGM 'Lamento della Ninfa' (Trailer Version)

'So you claim to know what I've suffered...?'

"No. But if love is not enough to conquer all and yet remains essential to fulfil a human being... that is why you feel incomplete. Just as I did. At least I understand what we are missing. What you need."

Red narrowed his eyes. A tacit admission.

The voices of the beasts rose. The conflict flared up again. Gold/Richter added:

"Your prestige weighed heavily on me. I felt unworthy both of succeeding you and of your reputation. Green is right: the young must certainly not surpass their elders.

I have stripped myself of a portion of my power. I need 'grey' means. To serve my uniqueness. To master the mechanisms with precision — whilst accepting my limitations, my vulnerabilities — so that I can truly help you."

BGM 'Lamento della Ninfa' (Trailer Version) 00:44–

Charizard cornered him. A corner of snow and rock. Focus Blast charged up. Houndoom braced for the consequences.

The attack was unleashed.

Houndoom leapt. Unusual agility. A Sucker Punch without a strike — just the dodge, rather like a feline. The force of it tore Red away from his speech.

Then the bite. Super Fang. Instinctive, ritualised, primitive fluidity — without losing oneself. Half-strength, no blood. Charizard staggered. A moment of dizziness.

Houndoom followed up. Crunch. Again. One of them sabotaged the defence. Charizard landed a Wing Attack on Houndoom in a panic to shake him off. Houndoom was forced back to a critically low HP. At the very last moment, Houndoom made it to the side, to safety.

BGM 'Lamento della Ninfa' (Trailer Version) 01:07

Red took it all in, panicking inside: savagery, yet tempered, for movements the civilised man does not anticipate.

Gold/Richter continued, further down.

'Being the strongest is the imprecation imposed upon you. The prohibition against losing robs you of love. If losing can restore your bond with others, it is the only way to restore the hero's dignity.

I must survive. Return to the one I love. So must you. You have someone to see again. That is your destiny...

BGM 'Lamento della Ninfa' (Trailer Version) 01:45

A flash. Chris/Maria. Affectionate. Clear.

Red could scarcely believe it. He had yearned for this moment for far too long. Yet he still had to preserve his opponent's dignity — and his own — to the very end.

Charizard, taken aback, prepared himself — a little too nonchalantly.

Gold/Richter drew his riding crop. The leather whistled through the dawn air. Not commanding. Ceremonious.

BGM 'Lamento della Ninfa' (Trailer Version) 02:00

Flashbulbs, laconic. Apollo at the tower, a businesslike gaze, an elegant posture. Eusine. His Haunter. Sucker Punch on Lambda's Koffing. Morty orders his Haunter to use Sucker Punch on the creatures of the night. Karin's generous and enigmatic smile.

White.

BGM 'Lamento della Ninfa' (Trailer Version) 02:11–end

We did not see the move. Houndoom lands, almost gracefully. The flashbacks are enough to analyse the move he used: Sucker Punch. The battle is decided.

Charizard collapsed onto its back. Calm. Resignation.

Dawn broke in full force and pierced the darkness.

End of scene

Scene — Imperfect Choices

Mt Silver — *high slopes, dawn*

BGM 'EP08 S02 14:15–14:38'

The darkness was being pierced. Red still couldn't believe it. Stunned, he sank to his knees. Dizziness. Snow settled on his knees.

A warmth, long buried, surged forth. Images, at first hazy, then clear: Charmeleon on the ground. Himself, surrendering. A deep, persistent frustration — and Misty, without condescension. She tolerated imperfection, loss. A loss in battle, not of life. He hadn't lost the bond. He'd gained one.

When he returned, the Water Badge was already in his hand. He was no longer preoccupied with winning, nor with wondering if he was being too lenient. He held the badge close to his heart. Just for that sense of liberation. Gratitude filled him.

The end of 'EP08 S02 14:15–14:38'.

He looked at Gold/Richter. Gold/Richter was gazing out at the scenery, taking it all in.

"...Mt. Silver... It didn't imprison you. It welcomed you. Neutral ground. So enchanting that I realise the grace of nature."

Houndoom approached, slowly. Almost like a dog.

Gold/Richter turned.

"...I didn't come here to transcend you. To prove to you... that I hadn't really overcome the trauma I faced with Apollo — and that now, I have. That I've been able to harness that power for righteous purposes."

Red could do nothing but listen further. Awestruck. Satisfied.

BGM 'A World to Win'

"You've made mistakes. So have I. Even Oak. Some are irreversible. Ours... not all of them. Not all of them in vain. Mt. Silver granted you sanctuary. We couldn't make amends. All you could do was level up to protect yourself, to protect others. After all these years, we've succeeded.

You're never entirely to blame. I survived. I was able to protect those I love... because you were right to choose Charmander."

Compassion welled up, warm and heartfelt. Everyone was praising Charizard. Hardly anyone had mentioned Charmander. The insults hurled at Green had not gone unanswered. He had not expected *this* person to still be alive.

'Thanks to you, I've met so many lovely people,' said Gold/Richter. 'I've come to be glad to be alive. To have met you. I just want to tell you... I'm so grateful to you...'

Red looked down at the snow, trying to shake off his unease. The feeling of having lost — not in battle. No objections.

BGM 'A World to Win' 00:40–01:10

Two shadows in the sky. They looked up together.

Ho-Oh. Lugia. They passed by. Their gazes met: two Trainers, four Pokémon, two birds. Forgiveness. A few seconds. A course already set. As if they'd anticipated it, and had come only to bestow a blessing.

Gold/Richter was filled with it — an audience, a wish for loyalty, perhaps. Red wondered:

'Are they here, specifically...?'

"They're always here. They can't show themselves easily. They're with us. Love. Mercy."

BGM "A World to Win" 01:10–01:40

They drifted away, slowly. The sky grew calm once more. At a time when few are awake to bear witness.

BGM "A World to Win" 01:40–02:06

Red turned to Charizard. Not fully recovered. But conscious enough. Its eyes offered encouragement — tinged with helplessness.

'...I'm sorry it's too hard for the Pokémon. There are some problems they simply can't solve, no matter what level they're at. All they can do is stand there and feel helpless...

But I'm glad you've always been by my side. Otherwise, I'd never have managed...'

Charizard took it in. An almost selfless contentment. The dawn all around no longer needed to break. It was already there.

End of scene

Scene — An urgent call

Mt Silver — *high slopes, dawn*

Red looked up. Pale as a sheet.

Gold/Richter was already slumping. On his knees. His composure was slipping. Houndoom took charge of the emergency without barking, without fanfare — just finding a way out, without overwhelming Red.

Red leapt out of the snow, holding nothing back.

'What's the matter with you...?'

"Sorry. I'm not as fit as I look..."

The preconception crumbled: challenging him had worn this lad down more than a champion.

A puzzled yet fitting smile, despite his exhaustion.

BGM "Powerful Predatory Deadly" 00:00 → 00:46

“You know... standing before you isn’t easy for many challengers. It’s worn me down over these past few months. Pressure. Anxiety...” said Gold/Richter

He struggled to hold on. The strain was plain to see.

Red was taken aback by something even simpler: he had never asked for his name.

“Wait. I haven’t even learnt your name...”

The energy drained away. Gold/Richter sank into his embrace — not serene. Almost childlike.

Red did not push him away. The burden grew heavier. He would not abandon him. There was no way out.

The river reflected the dawn too quickly—a hallucination of speed. All around, the snow, still only a thin layer, seemed to thicken. He lost his way.

He strayed from the path. His hands in his tailcoat pockets, too quickly, too clumsily. One pocket, then the other. Nothing. Again. The Poké Gear. It felt strange to touch that object. He switched it on. His fingers were too big, too cold. The screen lit up. Not so cryptic. Enough to make his throat loosen a little.

He released Skarmory, Fearow. Full Restore — them, Charizard. His movements were too quick to be sure.

BGM ‘Powerful Predatory Deadly’ 02:21 → end

Then the list. Unfamiliar names. He skimmed past them, too hastily, nearly missing one. Oak. The pain. He flinched, as if stepping back from a plaque. Blue — a relief, not yet. Green. Dread, without resentment: just too embarrassing. His thumb lingered there for too long.

He grew weary. He was about to resign himself to Blue.

Misty.

Not the best. Already a compromise. The awkwardness wouldn’t go away.

Hesitation. He dialled. A false press. Again. The hold music echoed too loudly in the dawn. Anxiety rose with every ring.

She picked up.

“Hello. Gold/Richter.”

The cheerful voice took him by surprise. He couldn’t think of anything to say.

“Why aren’t you answering...?”

He gathered his thoughts.

“Misty.”

“That voice is...”

An old familiarity, though he wasn’t quite sure yet.

“It’s me, Red.

I’d like you to do me a favour...”

End of scene

Scene — Mountain Syndrome

, Cerulean — Misty's house, an autumn day

The air was crisp. Human air, inescapable. On the table, the black tea was still steaming. Two cups. Too much space between them.

Red sat as if on trial. Misty didn't hold back her glances — accusatory, measured. She had changed. He, hardly at all. He kept his composure. But not his immunity.

She cut to the chase.

'I can well understand your reasons for leaving...

Hearing your voice through someone else's phone... after all these years... It's too insulting. You deserved a slap from me..."

He was not afraid of the slap. The rejection, for that reason alone, was enough to tear him apart. Misty grew even more indignant:

'Someone who's shut themselves away will get up the nerve to be so brazen. That's what I gather.'

"Sorry about all this."

"So how are you going to explain your escapade up to this point..."

She saw the hardship. The words wouldn't come. He was too timid to ask. Or perhaps he didn't know it was possible.

A pen. Some paper, lying beside him.

'If you'd like to start by writing,' she suggested.

More gentle than she'd expected. She adapted on the fly.

He took the pen as a compromise. He'd have been ashamed to need it, if he'd been in his shoes. He wrote, reservedly — yet more at ease.

Time passed. The conversation resumed, still one-sided. He was adapting. A little. Misty asked:

BGM 'My Sister' 00:00–00:30

'Why did you speak to me, and not to the others...?'

She was expecting certain answers. He spoke cautiously. Not particularly flattering:

'I trust you. Isn't that enough?'

"Am I the only one worthy of your trust?"

A dead end. Truth or complacency.

She stopped pressing him:

"Because you didn't want to call Oak and Green. Is that it?"

"I don't hate them."

"True. But that doesn't mean you don't want to avoid them. Because of what's already been awkward."

"As usual... you read me so well, Misty."

Affectionate. Sincere. Resigned.

She felt trapped in a different way. She didn't press the point.

"According to the doctor, the lad's in good shape. No physical risk. He's just overworked. We just need to put him up."

In the bedroom, Gold/Richter clung to the bed. Unconscious. Serene. Misty said:

BGM "EP08 S02 23:42–24:40"

"You've really found yourself an extraordinary successor."

"Yes. When I was taking him to your place, I came across four Golbat and two Misdreavus. They were being used to carry his belongings. Ironically."

"I saw the way he walked. Extravagant. Almost like yours."

"He doesn't really take after me. Otherwise I wouldn't have come back..."

No regrets about the debacle. Just a refusal to share the label. Misty explained:

"Simply because you're not from his generation. If you had been, your approach would have matched his. I find it hard to picture you wielding a whip. Like a vampire hunter, or something..."

The sarcasm was playful. The distance between them narrowed. Red found himself cheering up in spite of himself — a fleeting moment of amusement that dispelled the awkwardness.

She continued, more matter-of-factly.

"It's lovely to see you again, Red."

"...Me too."

The tea was no longer steaming quite so vigorously. The human air still held.

End of scene

Scene — The Materialised Spectre

, Route 25 — Kanto, 6–8 am, autumn

Pokémon birds in the bushes. A silence that was too still. As if it were foretelling something.

Gold/Richter was still limping. Just enough to stand up. Red opened up to him more than he ever had to anyone else.

"Are you feeling any better?"

"Not really. Just enough to get to my feet."

"That's good. That's more than enough. After your adventure..."

The sarcasm was not really for him.

"Yes... a wild adventure..." said Gold/Richter.

The bark. Medium volume. Quite forceful.

BGM 'Greatwords' 00:00 → 00:35

The foreboding of trauma, the residue of recurring memories: his terror was immediately visceral.

Apollo. And his Houndoom.

No emblem adorned his coat; the initial 'R' had been permanently removed. His suit remained an almost polar white, his black tie immaculate, his posture that of a man accustomed to poring over administrative files. A procedural, clinical, bureaucratic presence. He exuded a purely professional confidence, free from hatred, devoid of any spectacular boldness. He advanced like a ghost before coming to a standstill, and that very stillness was worse than movement.

Red felt the same stifling constraint, but he held it in to shield Gold/Richter's vulnerability.

Houndoom, for its part, waited for no verbal command. Its animosity was spontaneous, vampiric, antediluvian, ritualised. An inherent savagery one could scarcely anticipate in the modern world.

Gold/Richter slid his hand towards his belt to look for his hunting crop: the spot was empty. His Pokémon had remained in Misty's care, in Cerulean. Panic peaked, blindingly

Red assessed the extent of this distress; he felt indebted to his successor.

BGM 'Greatwords' 00:30 → 00:35

Houndoom did not attack. It merely ramped up its hostility a notch, just to emphasise the gravity of the situation

Apollo raised a hand. A tiny, graceful levitation, devoid of brute force. His gaze fell upon the two boys, disregarding the dog. The Houndoom did not calm down; it did not obey any moral code; it was simply weighing up the judgement, not the man. Here, physical conflict was unnecessary. Apollo spoke in a flat voice.

Apollo began:

The end of 'Greatwords' 00:35

'A superfluous hostility, Red. If you've heard my announcement regarding the permanent dissolution of Team Rocket.'

Red ceased his search for a Poké Ball with which to counter. Gold/Richter relaxed slightly, regaining his composure. This tiny gesture piqued Apollo's curiosity.

'As far as I recall, you've never seen me in person, Red... How do you explain these reactions?'

Red admitted, overcome by a lingering fear:

"I did not expect to meet you in the flesh. The true version of the person..."

"Understood," Apollo cut in with a laconic smile. "My identity has been borrowed for some treat or trick."

Gold/Richter, still sceptical:

'Why are you here...?'

Apollo replied without haste:

"Some ill-informed henchmen have committed acts of vandalism in the vicinity. I make it a point of honour to carry out this procedural check... Also for certain reasons... almost providential... Fateful. Who knows?"

They had nothing further to add. The air was heavy, thick with unspoken words. Apollo fixed his gaze on the cadet and observed:

BGM 'You've Seen the Devil'

"By all accounts, you have validated the correctness of your approach by bringing Red back to the living..."

A gloom settled over Gold/Richter, who replied with renewed stiffness:

"The world is not limited to your corrupt order. Savagery is real. Not indomitable. Not irreparable."

Apollo added, his voice waxy:

"...I had to admit defeat a moment ago. Now, your victory is complete."

Gold/Richter said:

"You could have harnessed that excellence and clarity in a fairer way," Gold/Richter replied, his throat tightening. "Not in such a cutting manner. Not so cynical..."

"I'm sorry. The lack of such opportunities back when I was starting out," retorted the white spectre.

"They would come to you again. If you submitted to justice."

Apollo rejected the offer with a slight gesture:

"...No, thank you."

That quiet firmness disheartened Gold/Richter more surely than the Houndoom's initial bark.

"So, you're no different from Giovanni. You're just like all those adults..."

An enigmatic smile flitted across Apollo's features, devoid of any presumption:

"Justice is formidable only to inherent, fundamental evil... Master Giovanni was so fainthearted that he had concocted an alibi to escape it. As for me, I am well aware of the law's shortcomings. Surrendering to it does not terrify me in the slightest."

"If you do not fear it, why decline this redemption?" insisted Gold/Richter

"How am I to explain this insistence on your part?"

"...I don't really want it. But I have resorted to your methods. Even to some of your wisdom. You deserve a second chance. For your own sake."

"Is this exception granted to me simply because I inadvertently contributed to your own success?"

“Yes. If you were eligible, you could still convert. Redemption...”

Gold/Richter sank back into a painful silence. Apollo then highlighted his interlocutor’s flaw, with chilling patience:

“Oh. You complained, Gold/Richter, that the masses had reduced Red to a mere symbol. Yet you are tending to do exactly the same to an antagonist...?”

Gold/Richter was struck flat by the remark. He struggled to believe what he had just heard — and the illusion he had just offered his enemy. The birds, hidden in the bushes, remained silent, still as death in the twilight.

End of scene

Scene — *Si Dolce E’l Tormento*

Route 25 — continued, 6–8 hours

Apollo spoke again, sounding a little more human — though he remained as still as a ghost.

BGM ‘Si Dolce E’l Tormento’

‘The law is not a remedy. It punishes; it prevents. It does not translate into lessons. To allow the perpetrator to use it as a moral lever would only subvert the world. Favouritism. Frivolity. It would destroy it.’

An anonymous, humiliating resentment seized Gold/Richter:

‘I am not so naive. I have not merely drawn upon your wisdom. I have also survived because you were unable to see it through to the end. Peace and progress sometimes depend on the incompleteness of the antagonists’ cruelty. It is humiliating. I must hold on to this gratitude. If you are entitled to it... you can still be saved... can’t you?’

Doubts were already stirring. Consciousness. Selective relief. He no longer knew what he was referring to. Apollo clarified:

“The law and justice cannot save every soul.”

The blow landed. Standing before him, Apollo’s demeanour was affable, chilling, pragmatic, truthful. Gold/Richter did not give up:

“...Giovanni’s son was saved by a flexibility in the application of justice. So that would work for you...?”

“Exceptions, favouritism and special dispensations do not alter this outcome. If he is the boy with red hair... he is still young. It is not too late. Some have already crossed the line.”

“Justice... cannot save every soul... even so?”

He repeated himself. Despair. Rejection. Apollo took his time.

Gold/Richter slumped. His knees. Tears. Red was taken aback by the breakdown. Gold/Richter poured out his heart:

“...I thought that becoming like Red would make the world a fairer place. I’ve given up on that solution, Gold/Richter. Now I have to accept that even justice cannot save everyone — not even certain souls who might have deserved it...”

Apollo said:

“Gold/Richter.”

The alternative opening of the BGM ‘Si Dolce E’l Tormento’

The name, never revealed. A surprise. The tears would not cease. Apollo explained:

“The spectre has deserted me.”

Eyes widened. The Old Man Coyote, as suggested by Apollo:

“Or perhaps I am of less use to him now. I cannot guarantee that my successors will be stronger, crueller, more insidious. Bringing me to justice would not be enough. You should probably continue to spurn me.”

Gold/Richter resisted:

“... I won’t be able to hate you forever...”

“Yes. You’re too good-natured for that. But you must recount my schemes, my manipulations. So that they may learn from them. Otherwise, your commitments would be in vain. And the spectre... would win.”

Gold/Richter’s tears flowed more freely:

“So why did I give up my dream, and fight all this way, if everything remains the same...?”

“You have estranged a part of yourself. Childish. Naive. Cutting it off too soon, too harshly, causes monumental pain. You have not been crushed by my accusation. By my words, inadvertently. And for the girl at your side, I presume. That is what prevents you from acknowledging this reality — not your incompetence. Just as I had not anticipated any possibilities other than your own.”

Apollo turned slightly towards Red. Teasing. Detached.

“The reason behind your decision... doesn’t sit right with that, does it, Red...?”

An awkward silence. A suggestive unanimity. Apollo continued:

“So you may be mistaken for as long as this affliction remains tenable.”

Gold/Richter asked:

“Why are you constantly so subversive, so perceptive... Helping this world whilst remaining despised...”

“I scoff at this world. It is you — and Red, no doubt — who wish to preserve it whilst knowing its ugliness. I cannot relieve you of that burden. To be of use, perhaps. Eventually.”

“I feared you... because you embody the possibility of the bad person I might have become. You spared me. I cannot set you free. I feel powerless...”

Apollo gave a sardonic smile, to himself:

"I have probably gained this clarity in exchange for certain limitations. Especially in the presence of someone whose life story is so similar. An incompleteness in my cruelty. Traces of humanity that I do not fully control."

Justice alone is not enough. It needs to be complemented. Perhaps that is why the tradition of Johto is not so set in its ways. It has survived my challenge.'

Gold/Richter attempted to interrupt. To no avail. Apollo continued:

'It's ironic coming from me, but children should not have to bear the whole burden alone. Share the load. Otherwise, you'll end up like the Red of old — alone with the shadow.'

He was about to leave. Gold/Richter cut in:

"You are always such a paradoxical mentor... The only one who can hurt me so deeply. I don't regret having met you..."

Awkwardness. Caustic gratitude. Contrition.

Apollo looked at him. A fleeting, cold melancholy, without tears. A trace of humanity, not quite under control. He read the intention:

"Plausibly. I cannot bring myself to believe that a child who exposed my deception, at such a heavy cost, would end up like me..."

End of scene

Scene — Some lessons are too heavy to learn alone

Route 25 — final

Their gazes held. A sudden leap: Apollo had already put some distance between them.

A hand was raised towards them. Polar gallantry. Detached.

−0:08 →

BGM 'Please Don't Leave Me'

"Farewell, Pokédex holders."

The air grew snowier. No snow.

He walked with his back half-turned, Houndoom at his side. His hands went into his pockets. A natural stride. Unhurried.

Gold/Richter remained on his knees. Tears. After a few steps, he needed support. Red steadied him. A sense of contrition: the price to reach him, to set him free.

Red tried. He knew how hard it was. The dead end.

BGM 'Please Don't Leave Me' 00:20–00:34

“Sorry for leaving you with this burden whilst I was away...”

He did not think he would ever get over it. Gold/Richter held his ground:

‘No. You shielded me from sin. From ending up like him...’

Resignation. The tears, warmer still. Gold/Richter continued:

BGM “Please Don’t Leave Me” 00:34–00:54

“It’s his way of protecting me. Even if it means remaining a monster...”

“...Is that a good outcome...?”

“No. But we mustn’t try to do everything. That’s all that matters.”

Red could not think of a retort. Gold/Richter remarked:

BGM “Please Don’t Leave Me” 00:54–01:12

“Some lessons come at too high a price. You don’t learn them by coming out unscathed. Without crashing and burning. For them, redemption comes too late. So we must respect the autonomy and the mortality of those who have paid that price for us...”

Apollo had no hindsight. No remorse.

At that very moment, his feelings were ambivalent: a lingering melancholy, a sombre bliss, the satisfaction of still being useful — and the cold, pragmatic, unfulfilled cruelty towards specific individuals.

Gold/Richter resigned himself to it. One thought held him: a lingering opportunity, so that it might not be quite so inexorable. Nothing was to be changed. Irreversible.

They walked away. The road ahead held nothing more.

End of episode

Close of episode

Totals

≈ 13,200 words · 39 pp. A4 · read aloud ≈ 90 min.

Pass 1/3 — still open

Gold/Richter only. space / vanished / coincided / was. OST titles out of headings. Curse notes here. White suit: one sheet. P1: back inverted; her embrace → his chest; Outbuilding → Dependence; quenched → Tempered; curse → imprecation (×2, not the move); Gold ×2 → Gold/Richter; mundane → banal; Relentlessness → Implacability; Loved Ones → Kin; Exceptional → Exceptions and Ordinary People.

Version notes

2026-09-24 — EN-GB apparatus after P1. Lamento treated as a named piece (Trailer Version). Traces = address. Author filled. Title: The Limits of Justice. Whip in Misty's mouth left open (sarcasm vs hunting-crop gel).

Open for what follows

Red among the living · Apollo gone · the Old Man Coyote still · Cerulean.

BGM credits

Nocturne pieces: Trevor Morris & Trey Toy. Traces: duration only.